

intent on making the reforms necessary to meet the challenges of the republic, and so he maneuvered himself into a position that would allow him to achieve his goal.

In 60BCE, Caesar became consul, and two years later he was appointed governor of the province of Gaul, a role which enabled him to remain abreast of developments in the Senate while also offering a springboard to military glory. In a series of masterful campaigns over the next eight years, he conquered Gaul, bringing the whole of what is now France, along with parts of Germany and Belgium, under his rule. He also led two expeditions to Britain, in 55 and 54BCE. Caesar's heroic military exploits left him immensely rich and increased his personal prestige; he enjoyed the loyalty of his armies and the love of the Roman mob, upon whom he could now afford to lavish feasts, games, and money.

Buoyed by his achievements, Caesar attempted to dictate the terms on which he would return to Roman politics, demanding to be allowed to stand for a second consulship while remaining in command at Gaul. This put him on a collision course with the Optimates in the Senate, since Roman law required military leaders to relinquish control of their armies before entering Rome, a prerequisite for running for office. Caesar knew that if he agreed to enter the city as a private citizen, without

his armies, his political opponents would most likely attempt to try him for abuse of power during his first consulship.

Back in Rome, the Optimates, alarmed by the implications of Caesar's meteoric rise, allied themselves to one of his main political rivals, the renowned general Pompey. The Senate passed laws intending to strip Caesar of his command when he returned from Gaul, and in 49BCE they declared him *hostis*, or public enemy. In response to this direct threat, Caesar did the unthinkable: he marched his army on Rome. En route, he paused at the border between the Gallic provinces and Italy proper: a small river called the Rubicon. Caesar was acutely aware that crossing the river would constitute a declaration of war against the Senate but, quoting the Athenian poet Menander, he announced *alea iacta est* ("let the dice roll") and led his men onward.

Caesar's new order

In the ensuing civil war, Caesar finally triumphed over Pompey's forces at the Battle of Pharsalus in northern Greece in 48BCE. The defeated Pompey fled to Egypt for sanctuary, where he was assassinated. After crushing the remaining pockets of resistance, Caesar finally returned to Rome in 45BCE, to consolidate his political position. In 46BCE he accepted the dictatorship for 10 years; two years later, he was granted the

Julius Caesar



Gaius Julius Caesar was born in Rome in 100BCE, to a patrician family of distinguished ancestry. From an early age, he grasped that money

was the key to power in a political system that had become hopelessly corrupt. He also quickly learned that forging a network of alliance and patronage would be crucial to his success.

After serving in the war to crush the slave revolt led by Spartacus in 72BCE, Caesar was briefly taken hostage by pirates. Once he returned to Rome in 60BCE, Caesar spent vast sums on buying influence and positions, eventually teaming up with the two other leading men in Rome,

Crassus and Pompey, to form the so-called First Triumvirate. Between 58 and 50BCE, he formed a provincial power base in Gaul where, without the sanction of the Senate, he launched a series of campaigns that made him master of Western Europe, with fabulous wealth and powerful armies. However, these campaigns also earned him many opponents among the governing classes, who would eventually cut short both his career and his life.